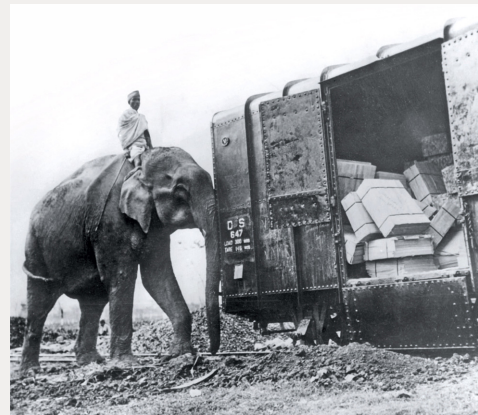


The extra traffic resulting from war was incredibly lucrative for the railways. This profitability, however, came at a heavy price as the railway system was worn out after being used far past its maximum capacity, with no subsequent repairs.

At the end of World War II in 1945, India's railways were in urgent need of repairs. However, the steam had gone out of the Empire in the subcontinent. The railway network was in shambles and in desperate need of renovation.

WATER, WATER EVERYWHERE!

The war effort involved innovative thinking and sometimes more indigenous solutions were found for problems. Elephants were used specially on the eastern war front, when diesel or steam power were unavailable. They would be transported in special elephant cars at the front of the train. In an interesting instance, a steam train transporting materiel to the frontier suddenly came to a halt. It had run out of water, despite having just filled the tank. Those who set out to investigate the issue immediately discovered the perpetrator— an elephant shamelessly using his trunk to suck water to give itself a bath. British soldiers on military train journeys caused similar grief to the engineers on board. Desperate for tea, but lacking a hot water source, every train stop would involve a crowd of soldiers rushing to drain hot water from the boilers.



▲ **An elephant** pushing a boxcar at Bogapani, Assam, in 1945